

ASEAN Scholars in Singapore Programme

Scholar Administration Handbook

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This document contains no real personal data, no real organisation names, and does not represent any actual scholarship policy. It was generated for the purpose of testing a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) prototype application.

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1. Introduction and Purpose of this Handbook

This handbook is issued by the ASEAN Scholars in Singapore Programme (ASSP) to provide scholars with a single, consolidated reference for the administrative policies, entitlements, and obligations associated with their scholarship award. It is intended to be read in conjunction with the individual Letter of Award issued to each scholar, which takes precedence in the event of any inconsistency.

The ASSP supports selected students to pursue full-time undergraduate or postgraduate study at approved overseas institutions, in exchange for a commitment to return and serve in an approved capacity for a defined bond period upon graduation. This handbook explains, in plain language, what scholars can expect from ASSP and what is expected of them throughout the duration of their award, from the point of acceptance through to the completion of their bond.

Scholars are strongly encouraged to read this handbook in full at the start of their award, and to refer back to it whenever a specific administrative question arises, such as applying for a leave of absence, understanding disbursement timelines, or seeking clarification on bond obligations. Where this handbook does not fully answer a question, scholars should reach out to their assigned Scholar Relations Officer (see Section 20 for contact details).

1.1 How This Handbook is Organised

This handbook is organised into twenty sections, moving broadly in chronological order from the point of award acceptance through to bond completion. Sections 2 to 4 cover the scholarship structure, application process, and financial support. Sections 5 to 9 cover ongoing obligations during the course of study. Sections 10 to 14 cover pastoral and welfare support available to scholars. Sections 15 to 17 cover dispute resolution, breach, and renewal processes. Sections 18 to 20 cover communication expectations, frequently asked questions, and contact information.

1.2 Updates to this Handbook

ASSP reviews this handbook on an annual basis, and reserves the right to amend its contents at any time to reflect changes in policy. Scholars will be notified of material changes via email and through the scholar portal. The version of this handbook in effect at the time a scholar accepted their award will generally continue to apply to that scholar, except where a policy change is explicitly stated to apply retroactively for reasons such as regulatory compliance or scholar safety.

2. The Aurora ASEAN Undergraduate Scholarship

This handbook uses the Aurora ASEAN Undergraduate Scholarship as its primary worked example throughout, since it is the most commonly awarded category under ASSP. The Aurora Scholarship funds four years of full-time undergraduate study at Marina Heights University in Singapore, leading to a Bachelor of Science in Computer Science. Other award categories exist (see Section 2.4) but follow the same general structure described here, with adjusted figures.

2.1 What the Aurora Scholarship Covers

- Full tuition fees at Marina Heights University, up to a cap of \$18,500 per academic year
- A monthly living allowance of \$1,350, disbursed in advance on the 1st of each month
- A one-time settling-in allowance of \$1,000, paid within the first two weeks of arrival
- A book and materials allowance of \$450 per academic year
- One return economy-class airfare per academic year, up to a cap of \$650
- Group medical insurance through Meridian Assist International Insurance for the full duration of study

2.2 Eligibility Criteria

- Minimum cumulative pre-university GPA of 3.5 out of 4.0, or equivalent
- Under 21 years of age at the point of application, with exceptions considered case-by-case
- Confirmed or in-progress admission to the BSc Computer Science programme at Marina Heights University
- Successful completion of the ASSP panel interview and written assessment

2.3 Duration and Bond

The Aurora Scholarship funds exactly 4 years of study. In exchange, recipients serve a bond period of 6 years (a multiplier of 1.5x) with an approved organisation upon graduation, as set out in full in Section 5.

2.4 Other Award Categories

ASSP also offers postgraduate and mid-career development scholarships at other approved institutions, which follow the same administrative framework described in this handbook but carry different funding caps, durations, and bond multipliers. Scholars in these categories should refer to their individual Letter of Award for their specific figures, and may otherwise treat this handbook's explanations of process and policy as equally applicable.

3. Application and Selection Process

The application and selection process for ASSP scholarships is designed to be rigorous, fair, and transparent. This section outlines the typical stages a candidate will progress through, from initial application to final award.

3.1 Application Submission

Applications are typically opened once per year, with the exact window announced through official channels including the ASSP website, participating schools, and relevant professional associations. Applicants are required to submit academic transcripts, a personal statement, at least two letters of recommendation, and, where applicable, evidence of university admission or admission-in-progress.

3.2 Shortlisting

A shortlisting panel reviews all complete applications against the published selection criteria. Applications are assessed holistically, taking into account academic merit, demonstrated commitment to the relevant field, leadership potential, and the applicant's articulated motivations for pursuing the scholarship.

3.3 Interviews

Shortlisted candidates are invited to attend one or more interview rounds, which may include a panel interview, a written assessment, and, for certain categories, a group exercise designed to assess collaborative and communication skills. Interview panels typically comprise a mix of senior officers, subject matter experts, and, where relevant, alumni of the scholarship programme.

3.4 Offer and Acceptance

Successful candidates receive a formal Letter of Award outlining the terms and conditions of their scholarship, including the approved field of study, the maximum funding quantum, the bond period, and any category-specific conditions. Candidates are typically given a defined window, commonly two to four weeks, to formally accept or decline the offer in writing. Failure to respond within this window may result in the offer being withdrawn.

3.5 Deferment of Award

In exceptional circumstances, such as a delay in university admission or a documented personal or medical emergency, a candidate may apply to defer the commencement of their award by up to one academic year. Deferment requests must be submitted in writing with supporting documentation and are subject to approval on a case-by-case basis.

4. Financial Support and Disbursement

This section explains, using the Aurora ASEAN Undergraduate Scholarship as the worked example, what financial support scholars receive and how funds are disbursed. Figures for other award categories differ and are set out in individual Letters of Award, but follow the same disbursement structure described here.

4.1 Components of Financial Support

Component	Amount	Frequency
Tuition fees	Up to \$18,500 / year	Paid directly to Marina Heights University
Living allowance	\$1,350 / month	Monthly, in advance
Settling-in allowance	\$1,000 (one-time)	Within 2 weeks of arrival
Book & materials allowance	\$450 / year	Start of each academic year
Return airfare	Up to \$650 / year	Once per academic year

4.2 Disbursement Schedule

The living allowance of \$1,350 is disbursed monthly in advance, on the 1st business day of each month, directly into the scholar's Marina Trust Bank International Student Account (see Section 21.4 for account setup). Tuition fees are paid directly to Marina Heights University based on that institution's own invoicing cycle, typically split into two payments of approximately \$9,250 each, in September and January.

4.3 Excess Costs

Where actual tuition fees exceed the \$18,500 annual cap, for example due to enrolment in an optional specialised module, the excess amount is the scholar's own responsibility unless a fee cap waiver has been separately approved in writing by ASSP.

4.4 Taxation

Scholars are responsible for understanding and complying with any tax obligations that may arise from their scholarship award, whether in Singapore or their home country. ASSP is unable to provide individual tax advice and recommends scholars consult a qualified tax professional if they have specific concerns.

5. Bond Obligations

In exchange for the financial support provided under this scholarship, scholars are required to serve a bond period with an approved organisation upon completion of their studies. This section explains how the bond period is calculated and what obligations apply during that period.

5.1 Calculation of Bond Period

For the Aurora ASEAN Undergraduate Scholarship, the bond period is calculated at a multiplier of 1.5x the funded study duration. Since the Aurora Scholarship funds exactly 4 years of study, this results in a bond period of 6 years. Other award categories use the same 1.5x multiplier for undergraduate awards, 2x for postgraduate Master's awards, and 2x for mid-career development awards, as set out in Appendix C.

5.2 Commencement of Bond

The bond period generally commences from the date the scholar takes up an approved full-time appointment following the completion of their studies. Where there is a gap between graduation and commencement of employment, scholars should notify their Scholar Relations Officer as soon as possible, as unexplained delays may be treated as a breach of bond conditions.

5.3 Approved Postings

Scholars are generally posted to a role that reflects both their field of study and organisational needs at the time of their return. While ASSP makes reasonable efforts to align postings with a scholar's stated interests and specialisation, the final posting decision rests with the receiving organisation and is not guaranteed to match any specific preference expressed by the scholar during their studies.

5.4 Break in Bond Service

Extended leave taken during the bond period, such as no-pay leave exceeding a specified threshold, maternity or paternity leave beyond statutory entitlements, or extended medical leave, may result in a corresponding extension of the bond period. Scholars should consult their Scholar Relations Officer before taking any extended leave during their bond period to understand how it may affect their bond completion date.

5.5 Early Release from Bond

In exceptional circumstances, a scholar may apply for early release from their remaining bond obligations. Applications are assessed on a case-by-case basis and, if approved, are typically subject to pro-rated repayment of the scholarship value corresponding to the unserved portion of the bond, in accordance with the formula set out in Section 16.

6. Academic Requirements and Performance Monitoring

Scholars are expected to maintain a satisfactory standard of academic performance throughout the duration of their funded study. This section explains the monitoring process and the consequences of underperformance.

6.1 Minimum Grade Requirements

Scholars must maintain at least the minimum cumulative grade point average, or equivalent standard, specified in their Letter of Award. This threshold is generally set to reflect a reasonably good, though not necessarily top-tier, standard of academic performance, recognising that scholars are also expected to engage meaningfully in co-curricular and leadership activities during their studies.

6.2 Academic Progress Reports

Scholars are required to submit an academic progress report, generally including an official transcript, at the end of each academic term or semester, depending on the structure of their host institution. Reports should be submitted through the scholar portal within four weeks of results being released by the institution.

6.3 Academic Probation

A scholar whose grades fall below the minimum threshold specified in their Letter of Award for two consecutive terms may be placed on academic probation. Scholars on academic probation will be required to meet with their Scholar Relations Officer to discuss a improvement plan, which may include reduced course loads, additional academic support, or, in more serious cases, a review of the scholar's continued eligibility for the award.

6.4 Academic Misconduct

Any finding of academic misconduct by the host institution, including but not limited to plagiarism, examination misconduct, or falsification of results, must be reported to ASSP by the scholar within two weeks of the finding being made. Failure to disclose a finding of academic misconduct is itself treated as a serious breach of the scholarship terms, independent of the underlying misconduct finding.

7. Leave of Absence and Course Extensions

7.1 Leave of Absence During Study

Scholars who need to take a temporary break from their studies, for reasons such as medical circumstances, family emergencies, or approved participation in a structured exchange or internship programme, must apply for a Leave of Absence through the scholar portal. Applications should be submitted at least four weeks in advance where the circumstance is foreseeable, or as soon as reasonably possible in the case of an emergency.

7.2 Documentation Required

- A completed Leave of Absence application form
- Supporting documentation appropriate to the reason for leave, such as a medical certificate for medical leave
- Written acknowledgement from the host institution confirming the leave arrangement, where applicable

7.3 Effect on Financial Support

Living allowance disbursements are generally paused during an approved Leave of Absence exceeding one month, and resume once the scholar confirms their return to study. Scholars should plan their finances accordingly and notify ASSP promptly of both the commencement and conclusion of any leave period.

7.4 Course Extensions

Where a scholar is unable to complete their approved course of study within the originally funded duration, for reasons such as a change in course structure, required repeat modules, or personal circumstances, they may apply for a course extension. Extensions are not guaranteed and are assessed based on the reason for the delay, the scholar's overall academic record, and the availability of continued funding.

7.5 Extensions Due to Change in Programme Structure

Where a host institution unilaterally changes its programme structure in a way that extends the expected duration of study, through no fault of the scholar, ASSP will generally approve a corresponding extension of funding, subject to verification with the institution.

8. Change of Course, University, or Country

Scholars are expected to complete their studies in the course, institution, and country approved at the point of award. Any proposed change must be formally applied for and approved in advance; changes made without prior approval may affect a scholar's continued eligibility for funding.

8.1 Change of Course

A request to change to a different course of study, even within the same institution, should be submitted with a clear explanation of the reason for the change and how the new course continues to align with the scholar's original area of specialisation, or with a genuine organisational need. Requests that represent a significant departure from the original field of study are less likely to be approved.

8.2 Change of Institution

Requests to transfer to a different institution are generally only approved in exceptional circumstances, such as the discontinuation of a programme, a documented safety concern, or a significant and unforeseen change in personal circumstances. Scholars should be aware that a change of institution may affect the funding cap applicable to their award.

8.3 Change of Country

Requests to relocate studies to a different country entirely are subject to the most stringent review, given the implications for visa arrangements, cost of living calculations, and overall programme alignment. Such requests should only be submitted where there is a compelling and well-documented reason.

9. Code of Conduct while Overseas

As a recipient of public or organisational sponsorship, scholars are expected to conduct themselves in a manner that reflects positively on ASSP and the broader community they represent while studying overseas.

9.1 General Standards of Conduct

- Comply with all local laws and regulations of the host country
- Comply with the disciplinary code and academic integrity policies of the host institution
- Refrain from conduct that could bring \${SHORT} or its scholars into disrepute
- Promptly disclose any arrest, criminal charge, or disciplinary proceeding to their Scholar Relations Officer

9.2 Political Activity

Scholars are generally expected to refrain from active involvement in partisan political activity in their host country during the period of their award, consistent with their position as a sponsored representative. Scholars with questions about specific activities are encouraged to seek clarification from their Scholar Relations Officer before participating.

9.3 Social Media Conduct

While scholars are free to maintain personal social media accounts, they are encouraged to exercise good judgement in what they post, particularly in relation to content that could be perceived as reflecting an official position, or that could bring ASSP into disrepute.

9.4 Reporting Obligations

Scholars are required to promptly report to their Scholar Relations Officer any incident that may affect their wellbeing, safety, or continued eligibility for the scholarship, including but not limited to serious illness, involvement in a legal proceeding, or any safety incident affecting the scholar directly.

10. Accommodation and Living Arrangements

Scholars are generally responsible for arranging their own accommodation while studying overseas, with support and guidance available from ASSP where needed. For scholars attending Marina Heights University, this section includes specific information on the recommended first-year hostel.

10.1 Recommended First-Year Accommodation

ASSP has a standing arrangement with Dover Halls of Residence, located at 12 Meridian Walk, Singapore 138678, approximately a 12-minute walk from the Marina Heights University main campus. First-year Aurora scholars are strongly encouraged, though not required, to take up accommodation here, as it offers a pre-negotiated rate of \$780 per month inclusive of utilities and WiFi, and places scholars within easy reach of other first-year students including fellow scholars.

10.2 Applying for Cross Lane Halls

Scholars wishing to take up this arrangement should indicate their interest through ASSP Connect at least 8 weeks before the start of term. ASSP will coordinate directly with Dover Halls of Residence management to confirm the booking; scholars do not need to apply separately through the hostel's own website.

10.3 Alternative Accommodation

From the second year onwards, most scholars move to private rental accommodation in the wider Singapore area, such as Clementi, Bukit Timah, or Queenstown. ASSP does not mandate a specific accommodation type beyond the first year, but encourages scholars to prioritise safety, proximity to campus, and affordability within their \$1,350 monthly living allowance.

10.4 Accommodation Support

Scholars relocating for the first time may request a consultation with their Scholar Relations Officer or with alumni who previously studied at Marina Heights University, to gain practical advice on accommodation options in Singapore beyond the first year.

10.5 Shared Accommodation with Non-Scholars

Scholars are free to share accommodation with fellow students who are not part of the scholarship programme, subject to the general expectation that such arrangements do not compromise the scholar's safety, academic performance, or ability to comply with their reporting obligations under this handbook.

11. Health, Insurance, and Emergency Support

11.1 Medical Insurance

ASSP arranges group medical insurance for all scholars through Meridian Assist International Insurance (Policy Series ASSP-AUR) for the full duration of funded study, covering hospitalisation, outpatient treatment up to \$2,500 per year, and emergency medical evacuation. Scholars receive their individual policy number and a digital insurance card via ASSP Connect within the first week of their award commencing, and should familiarise themselves with the coverage terms, including any exclusions.

11.2 Pre-Existing Conditions

Scholars with pre-existing medical conditions should disclose these at the point of application, so that appropriate insurance arrangements and any necessary support can be put in place ahead of their departure.

11.3 Mental Health Support

Recognising the challenges of studying overseas, ASSP provides access to a confidential counselling helpline for all scholars, as well as periodic wellbeing check-ins conducted by Scholar Relations Officers. Scholars experiencing mental health difficulties are strongly encouraged to reach out early, either through this helpline, their host institution's student wellbeing services, or their Scholar Relations Officer.

11.4 Emergency Contact Protocol

In the event of a medical, safety, or other emergency, scholars should first seek appropriate local emergency assistance, then notify ASSP's 24-hour emergency contact line as soon as reasonably practicable. Contact details are provided in Section 20 and in the welcome pack issued at the start of the award.

12. Travel Arrangements

This section explains, in detail, how flight costs are covered at each stage of a scholar's journey — from initial arrival in Singapore, through annual trips home during the scholarship, to the final return flight home after studies are completed.

12.1 Initial Departure to Singapore

Upon accepting the Aurora Scholarship, scholars book their own outbound flight to Singapore, in economy class, on a route and airline of their choosing. ASSP reimburses this cost up to a cap of \$650, upon submission of the flight itinerary, boarding pass, and receipt through ASSP Connect within 30 days of arrival. Scholars are encouraged to book at least 6 weeks in advance to secure fares within this cap; where fares genuinely exceed the cap due to limited route availability from certain home countries, scholars may apply for a higher cap via their Scholar Relations Officer, with supporting evidence of at least three fare comparisons.

12.2 Scholars Under 16: Escort and Unaccompanied Minor Arrangements

Scholars who are under 16 years of age at the point of initial departure are required to either travel with a parent or guardian, or be booked on an airline's Unaccompanied Minor (UM) service. Where a parent or guardian accompanies the scholar, ASSP does not cover the accompanying adult's airfare or accommodation costs. Where the UM service is used, ASSP reimburses the UM service fee in addition to the base airfare, up to a combined cap of \$850, and coordinates with the receiving Scholar Relations Officer to confirm airport collection arrangements in Singapore.

12.3 Annual Return Airfare

From the second year of the scholarship onwards, scholars are entitled to one return economy-class airfare per academic year between Singapore and their home country, up to a cap of \$650 per trip. This entitlement is intended to allow scholars to spend the year-end vacation period (typically late November to early January) with their families, though scholars may use it flexibly across the year, including splitting it to attend a specific family event, subject to prior notification to their Scholar Relations Officer at least 2 weeks in advance.

12.4 Unused Annual Airfare

The annual return airfare entitlement does not carry over if unused in a given academic year, and cannot be exchanged for cash. Scholars who do not wish to travel home in a particular year are encouraged to use the entitlement to host a family member's visit to Singapore instead, up to the same \$650 cap, by submitting the family member's flight receipt in place of their own.

12.5 Emergency Travel Home

In the event of a family emergency, such as a serious illness or bereavement, ASSP will cover an emergency return flight home outside of the annual entitlement, up to \$900, regardless of how much of the annual entitlement has already been used that year. Scholars should contact their Scholar Relations Officer or the 24-hour emergency line (Section 20.2) as soon as possible to activate this support, as approval can typically be given within hours for genuine emergencies.

12.6 Final Return Flight After Graduation

Upon successful completion of studies, ASSP covers one final one-way economy-class flight from Singapore back to the scholar's home country, up to a cap of \$650, to be used within 60 days of the scholar's final examination or thesis submission, whichever is later. This is separate from, and does not affect, any travel arrangements associated with the scholar's subsequent bond posting, which are covered under a separate posting relocation allowance communicated at the time of posting (see Section 14).

12.7 Excess Baggage

Excess baggage charges are not covered as part of the standard travel arrangements described above, except for the final return flight after graduation (Section 12.6), where scholars may claim up to \$120 in excess baggage fees to account for accumulated belongings, upon submission of the airline receipt.

12.8 Personal Travel

Scholars are free to undertake personal travel during vacation periods at their own expense, provided such travel does not interfere with academic obligations. Scholars are required to notify their Scholar Relations Officer of personal travel plans exceeding 5 days, and are strongly encouraged to do so for any travel to a country or region with an elevated travel advisory, so that ASSP can include them in relevant safety communications.

13. Mentorship and Pastoral Care

13.1 Scholar Relations Officers

Each scholar is assigned a dedicated Scholar Relations Officer, who serves as their primary point of contact for administrative matters, pastoral support, and general guidance throughout their award. Scholars are encouraged to maintain regular contact with their Scholar Relations Officer, even in the absence of a specific issue to raise.

13.2 Alumni Mentorship Programme

ASSP operates a voluntary mentorship programme connecting current scholars with alumni who have completed similar courses of study or who are now serving in similar roles. Scholars may request a mentor match through the scholar portal.

13.3 Peer Support Networks

Scholars studying in the same city or region are encouraged to connect with one another through periodic in-person or virtual gatherings organised by ASSP, providing an informal peer support network alongside the more formal mentorship and Scholar Relations Officer channels.

13.4 Family Support

ASSP recognises that a scholar's family may also experience the effects of an overseas posting, both during study and during the subsequent bond period. Where relevant, family members may reach out to the Scholar Relations Officer for general guidance, subject to the scholar's consent for information to be shared.

14. Career Guidance and Post-Graduation Placement

14.1 Career Conversations

In the final year of study, scholars will typically be invited to a series of career conversations with their Scholar Relations Officer to discuss their interests, strengths, and preferences ahead of their return and posting.

14.2 Posting Process

As noted in Section 5, final posting decisions take into account both organisational needs and scholar preferences, though a perfect match cannot be guaranteed in every case. Scholars will generally be informed of their posting several months ahead of their expected return date, to allow time for practical preparation.

14.3 Onboarding Support

Scholars returning to take up their first posting will typically go through a structured onboarding programme, which may include orientation sessions, a probationary review period, and continued access to mentorship support during the transition.

15. Grievance and Dispute Resolution

15.1 Informal Resolution

Scholars who have a concern or disagreement regarding the administration of their scholarship are encouraged, in the first instance, to raise the matter informally with their Scholar Relations Officer, who will attempt to resolve the matter directly wherever possible.

15.2 Formal Grievance Process

Where a matter cannot be resolved informally, a scholar may submit a formal written grievance through the scholar portal. Formal grievances are reviewed by a panel independent of the scholar's usual Scholar Relations Officer, and a written response is generally provided within four to six weeks.

15.3 Appeals

A scholar who disagrees with the outcome of a formal grievance may request a further review by a senior appeals panel, whose decision is generally treated as final in relation to the specific matter raised.

16. Termination and Breach of Bond

16.1 Grounds for Termination

ASSP may terminate a scholarship award prior to completion in circumstances including, but not limited to, serious academic misconduct, failure to meet minimum academic requirements over a sustained period, serious breach of the code of conduct, or provision of false information at the point of application.

16.2 Breach of Bond

A scholar who fails to commence or complete their bond service without an approved reason, including resignation prior to bond completion, is generally considered to be in breach of their bond and may be liable to repay the scholarship, typically calculated on a pro-rated basis reflecting the unserved portion of the bond period, together with accrued interest as specified in the Letter of Award.

16.3 Repayment Arrangements

Where repayment is required, ASSP will generally work with the scholar to agree a reasonable repayment plan, taking into account the scholar's financial circumstances, though the specific terms remain at the discretion of ASSP on a case-by-case basis.

16.4 Waiver of Bond Liability

In rare and exceptional circumstances, such as serious and permanent medical incapacity, ASSP may consider a full or partial waiver of outstanding bond liability. Such requests must be submitted in writing with comprehensive supporting documentation.

17. Annual Review and Scholarship Renewal

17.1 Annual Review Process

For multi-year awards, continuation of funding into each subsequent academic year is generally subject to an annual review, taking into account the scholar's academic performance, conduct, and continued eligibility. This review is not intended to be onerous for scholars who are meeting the expected standards, but exists to ensure ongoing alignment between the scholar and the programme.

17.2 Notification of Renewal

Scholars will generally be notified of the outcome of their annual review, including confirmation of continued funding for the following academic year, within four weeks of submitting their end-of-year academic progress report.

18. Communication and Reporting Requirements

18.1 Regular Check-Ins

Scholars are expected to respond to periodic check-in communications from their Scholar Relations Officer, generally sent on a termly or semesterly basis, within a reasonable timeframe, typically within two weeks.

18.2 Change of Personal Details

Scholars must promptly update their contact details, including address, phone number, and emergency contact information, through the scholar portal whenever these change, to ensure ASSP is able to reach them in the event of an emergency.

18.3 Scholar Portal

The scholar portal serves as the primary channel through which scholars submit required documentation, including academic progress reports, leave applications, and updates to personal details. Scholars should check the portal regularly for notifications and announcements.

19. Frequently Asked Questions

What happens if I fail a module?

A single failed module does not automatically place you on academic probation, but it should be disclosed in your next academic progress report along with any plan to retake the module. Repeated failures, or a resulting drop below the minimum grade threshold, may trigger the academic probation process described in Section 6.

Can I work part-time while studying?

Scholars may generally undertake limited part-time work during term time and full-time work during vacation periods, subject to the visa conditions of their host country and provided it does not affect academic performance. Scholars should check with their Scholar Relations Officer if unsure.

What if I want to get married during my studies?

There is no restriction on a scholar's personal life decisions such as marriage. However, scholars should notify their Scholar Relations Officer if a change in personal circumstances, such as marriage or relocation of a spouse, may affect their accommodation, living allowance calculation, or bond planning.

Can my bond period run concurrently with another bond I owe?

In most cases, bond periods run consecutively rather than concurrently, unless a specific written exception has been approved. Scholars with pre-existing bonds to another organisation should raise this at the point of application.

What happens if I want to pursue a different postgraduate qualification after completing my current one?

Scholars wishing to pursue further study before commencing their bond service should discuss this with their Scholar Relations Officer well in advance, as this may affect the bond commencement date and could require a separate approval process.

Who do I contact if I lose my passport overseas?

Scholars should first contact the nearest relevant consular office for emergency travel document support, and then notify their Scholar Relations Officer and the 24-hour emergency contact line as described in Section 11.

Is the living allowance the same regardless of city?

No. The living allowance is calculated based on the specific cost of living in the scholar's city of study, and is reviewed periodically to reflect changes in cost of living.

What if my host university goes on strike or suspends classes?

Extended disruptions to teaching caused by circumstances outside the scholar's control, such as industrial action or institutional closures, are generally taken into account when assessing any resulting need for a course extension, as described in Section 7.

20. Contact Directory and Resources

20.1 General Enquiries

For general administrative enquiries, scholars should first log a request through ASSP Connect, which is monitored by the Scholar Relations team on weekdays, 9:00am to 6:00pm. General enquiries email: scholars@assp-example.org.

20.2 24-Hour Emergency Line

A 24-hour emergency contact line, +1-800-555-0199, is available for urgent matters involving scholar safety or welfare. This number is also printed on the back of each scholar's Meridian Assist International Insurance insurance card.

20.3 Confidential Counselling Helpline

A confidential counselling helpline, +1-800-555-0142, operated by an independent third-party provider (MindWell Support Services), is available to all scholars free of charge, 24 hours a day, for the duration of their award.

20.4 Feedback

ASSP welcomes feedback on this handbook and on the overall scholar experience. Suggestions may be submitted at any time through the feedback form available on ASSP Connect.

21. Pre-Departure and Arrival Guide

This section consolidates the practical, logistical information scholars need in the weeks before departure and during their first few weeks overseas. Much of this content was previously scattered across multiple briefings and welcome emails; it is now centralised here for ease of reference.

21.1 Pre-Departure Checklist

- Confirm Overseas Scholar Pass (OSP) approval, issued by Singapore Entry & Residency Authority (SERA), and print at least two physical copies of the approval letter
- Complete the pre-departure medical check-up with an approved panel clinic in your home country
- Activate international roaming or arrange a local eSIM for your first week in Singapore
- Register your Singapore accommodation address with ASSP Connect once confirmed
- Photocopy your passport, Overseas Scholar Pass (OSP) approval letter, and Letter of Award, and store copies separately from the originals
- Attend the mandatory Pre-Departure Briefing, typically held 4-6 weeks before the start of term, usually conducted online for scholars still in their home country

21.2 Suggested Packing List

Singapore has a tropical climate, so packing needs differ from what scholars from cooler climates may expect. The following categories are commonly raised by past scholars as easy to overlook:

- Light, breathable clothing suited to Singapore's warm and humid climate year-round
- A light jacket or long-sleeved layer for heavily air-conditioned indoor spaces such as lecture halls and shopping malls
- A universal power adaptor compatible with Singapore's Type G power outlets
- A small first-aid kit and a 1-2 week supply of any regular prescription medication, with the prescription letter
- Physical copies of key documents (see 21.1), stored separately from your checked luggage
- A compact umbrella — Singapore experiences frequent short bursts of rain year-round

21.3 Airport Arrival Support

For scholars arriving in Singapore for the first time, ASSP coordinates a volunteer airport greeting service at Singapore Changi Airport, generally provided by a local alumni or senior scholar volunteer. This service is optional and subject to volunteer availability; scholars who wish to use it should register their flight details through ASSP Connect at least two weeks before arrival. Where this service is unavailable, scholars will be provided with pre-arranged airport transfer options as part of their orientation pack.

21.4 First-Week Administrative Tasks

- Register with Marina Heights University and collect your student identification card
- Open a Marina Trust Bank International Student Account — bring your passport, Overseas Scholar Pass (OSP), and Confirmation of Acceptance letter from Marina Heights University; no proof of address is required to open the account
- Complete your address registration via the Singapore Entry & Residency Authority (SERA) e-Registration portal within 7 days of arrival, as required for all Overseas Scholar Pass (OSP) holders

- Activate your Solis Mobile eSIM or collect a physical SIM card from the Solis Mobile kiosk at Singapore Changi Airport (Terminal 3, opposite the currency exchange)
- Purchase a MeridianPass card (\$25 refundable deposit) for discounted travel on Singapore's MRT and bus network
- Attend the Marina Heights University international student orientation, in addition to the ASSP welcome session described below
- Locate the nearest pharmacy and register with a General Practitioner (GP) clinic near your accommodation — the campus Student Health Centre can assist with GP recommendations during Orientation Week

21.5 Orientation Programme

In addition to Marina Heights University's own orientation activities, ASSP holds a welcome session for new Aurora scholars during the first two weeks of term, at the ASSP Welcome Centre (8 Meridian Avenue, Singapore 179803). This session covers a walkthrough of ASSP Connect, an introduction to the local Scholar Relations Officer, and an opportunity to meet other scholars and alumni in Singapore.

22. Life During Term: Practical Resources

22.1 Term Dates and Vacation Periods

Term dates follow Marina Heights University's academic calendar, which generally runs two semesters per year, from August to December and January to May, with a longer vacation period from May to July and a shorter break in December. Scholars should plan use of their annual return airfare entitlement (see Section 12) around these vacation windows.

22.2 Travelling Home During Term

Scholars wishing to travel home during term time, outside of scheduled vacation periods, should notify their Scholar Relations Officer in advance and confirm that such travel does not conflict with academic commitments such as examinations or mandatory coursework deadlines. Repeated unscheduled travel during term time may be raised as part of the academic performance conversation described in Section 6.

22.3 Support During Examination Periods

ASSP recognises that examination periods can be particularly stressful, especially for first-year scholars adjusting to a new academic system. Scholar Relations Officers conduct a light-touch check-in with all scholars ahead of major examination periods, and the confidential counselling helpline (see Section 11) remains available throughout.

22.4 Preparing for Post-Graduation Transition

In a scholar's final year, in addition to the career conversations described in Section 14, ASSP runs a transition workshop covering practical matters such as closing overseas bank accounts, shipping or donating belongings, cancelling local subscriptions and tenancy agreements, and understanding what to expect in the first few weeks of the return process.

22.5 Staying Connected with the Scholar Community

Scholars are automatically added to a private online community space for their cohort upon commencement of their award, used for informal peer support, sharing of practical tips specific to their study destination, and occasional community-organised meetups. Participation is optional but strongly encouraged, particularly for scholars who are the only one from their cohort studying in a particular city.

23. Glossary of Terms

Bond

The period of service a scholar is obligated to complete with an approved organisation following graduation, in exchange for the financial support received during their studies.

Bond Multiplier

The ratio used to calculate bond length based on years of funded study, e.g. a multiplier of 1.5 applied to 4 years of study results in a 6-year bond.

Letter of Award

The formal document issued to a successful applicant setting out the specific terms and conditions of their individual scholarship.

Scholar Relations Officer

The named individual assigned to each scholar as their primary point of contact for administrative and pastoral matters.

Scholar Portal

The online system through which scholars submit reports, applications, and updates, and through which they receive official communications.

Leave of Absence

A formally approved, temporary pause in a scholar's studies.

Academic Probation

A formal status applied when a scholar's academic performance falls below the minimum required standard, triggering additional monitoring and support.

Settling-in Allowance

A one-time payment made at the start of a scholarship to help cover initial relocation costs.

Pro-rated Repayment

A repayment amount calculated in proportion to the unserved portion of a bond or unused portion of funding.

Host Institution

The overseas university or college at which a scholar is enrolled for their approved course of study.

Appendix A: Leave of Absence Application Checklist

Scholars applying for a Leave of Absence, as described in Section 7, should ensure the following items are prepared before submitting their application through the scholar portal:

- Completed Leave of Absence application form, including proposed start and end dates
- A brief written explanation of the reason for the requested leave
- Supporting documentation appropriate to the reason (e.g. medical certificate, official correspondence)
- Written acknowledgement from the host institution confirming the arrangement, where applicable
- Updated contact details for the duration of the leave period
- Confirmation of intended date of return to studies

Applications missing any of the above items may be returned to the scholar for completion, which can delay processing. Scholars are encouraged to reach out to their Scholar Relations Officer if they are uncertain about any part of this checklist.

Stage	Typical Timeframe	Responsible Party
Application submitted	Day 0	Scholar
Initial review	Within 5 business days	Scholar Relations Officer
Additional information requested (if needed)	Within 10 business days	Scholar Relations Officer
Final decision communicated	Within 15 business days	Scholar Relations Officer
Confirmation of return to studies	As per agreed return date	Scholar

Appendix B: Academic Progress Report — Sample Structure

Scholars are required to submit an Academic Progress Report at the end of each academic term, as described in Section 6. The following provides a sample structure that scholars can expect to complete through the scholar portal.

Section	Description
Term / Semester	The specific academic term being reported on
Modules Enrolled	A list of all modules or courses undertaken during the term
Grades / Results	Official grades or results for each module, or 'pending' if not yet released
Cumulative GPA / Average	The scholar's updated cumulative academic standing
Co-curricular Activities	A brief summary of any leadership, community, or extracurricular involvement during the term
Wellbeing Check-in	A short self-reported reflection on general wellbeing and any support needs
Upcoming Term Plans	Modules or activities planned for the following term

Scholars are welcome to add any additional context they feel is relevant, particularly where academic performance has been affected by circumstances outside their control, so that this can be taken into account during the review process described in Section 6.

Appendix C: Indicative Bond Multiplier Table

The table below provides an indicative illustration of how bond periods are typically calculated relative to years of funded study. Actual multipliers applicable to a specific scholar are set out in their individual Letter of Award and may vary by award category.

Scholarship Category	Years of Funded Study	Indicative Bond Multiplier	Indicative Bond Period
Undergraduate	4 years	1.5x	6 years
Undergraduate (shorter course)	3 years	1.5x	4.5 years
Postgraduate (Master's)	1-2 years	2x	2-4 years
Postgraduate (Doctoral)	3-4 years	1.5x	4.5-6 years
Mid-Career Development	1 year	2x	2 years

This table is provided for illustrative purposes only and does not constitute a binding commitment. Scholars should always refer to their individual Letter of Award as the authoritative source for their specific bond obligations.

— *End of Handbook (Sample / Fictional Document)* —